

Liquid Insight

US rates: stay paid, conviction lower

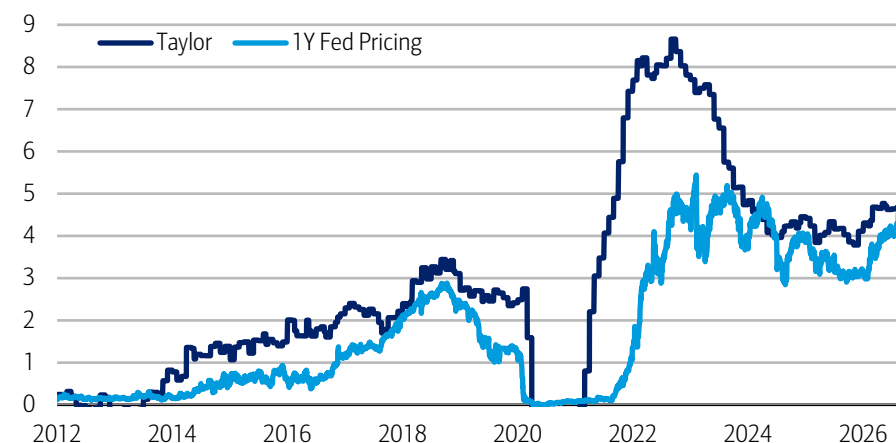
Key takeaways

- We stay paid US 2Y & in flatteners after Friday's softer NFP but with lower conviction
- Higher front end rates should be supported by strong US economy, easy fin conditions, commodity risks, and technicals
- Conviction reduced w/pricing, Fed guidance, small rate bite, de-risking. Soft data or big FCI tightener needed to shift views

By Mark Cabana

Exhibit 1: Taylor rule implied US policy rate & 1Y Fed pricing (%)

Market is now pricing Fed outcome much closer to Taylor-implied policy rate



Source: BofA Global Research, Bloomberg; note: Taylor uses Fed SEP r^* , u^* , & i^*

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We stay paid US 2Y & in flatteners after Friday's softer NFP but with lower conviction. Our logic: (1) strong US economy, (2) easy financial conditions, (3) upside commodity risks, (4) technical support. Strong macro + easy conditions = higher front-end rates.

Our conviction in US duration & curve views has been reduced due to: (1) markets that better price policy path (Exhibit 2), (2) Fed push back, (3) early signs of financial conditions rate bite, (4) investor de-risking & closing UST underweights.

Overall, we continue to believe that US rates will remain elevated or rise further until macro data softens or financial conditions tighten. We do not believe either condition has yet been sufficiently met, which should support ongoing sticky inflation concern. It should also support upside rate & Fed hike risks. Higher rates may shift from front-end to belly / back end if Fed stays dovish, challenging flatteners.

05 October 2026

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Sept NFP: salient seasonals

The September jobs report came in soft but not terribly out of line with the expected drag from seasonal factors. The three-month average job gains (50k) remain above breakeven, even after downward revisions. On an unrounded basis, the u-rate only moved from 4.14% to 4.17%, a benign move, especially with the LFPR (Labor Force Participation Rate) up. See: [US Watch: Sep jobs report](#). Overall, the report reinforces the stable labor & limited wage pressure narrative.

October Fed pricing was unsurprisingly pared back after the labor data. October hike likelihood has been reduced from a peak of 18bps (70% likelihood) on Sept 29 to 5bps (~20% likelihood) today. Risks have shifted away from our US Economics team call for an Oct hike. They write: “we will revisit the October hike call after the Sep inflation releases”.

US rates initially rallied after the soft data release but fully reversed the move over the day. The reversal was driven by higher commodity prices & may reflect that positioning is not as short as expected. Risk asset increase after the soft labor data may have also supported a reduction of flight to quality flows from earlier in the week.

Pay 2Y: robust activity, easy FCI, & commodity risks

We stay paid US 2Y & in 2s30s flatteners after the soft labor data. We stay paid due to:

Robust US activity: Q3 GDP tracking: BofAe = 3.5%, Atlanta Fed GDP now = 3.7%. US consumer spending remains resilient with spending ex gas >4-5% (see: [BofA on USA report](#)). Economic surprise indices have flattened out but underlying activity remains robust.

Easy financial conditions: broad financial conditions have been minimally impacted by the sharp global rate rise. In Sept 2Y-10Y US rates rose >50bps & US equities / credit barely budged. The Chicago Fed financial conditions index is little changed (Exhibit 3) & over 50% of BofA clients describe US monetary policy as “accommodative” (Exhibit 4).

Exhibit 2: Chicago Fed financial conditions index remains very low

Chicago Fed financial conditions has been easing since '23

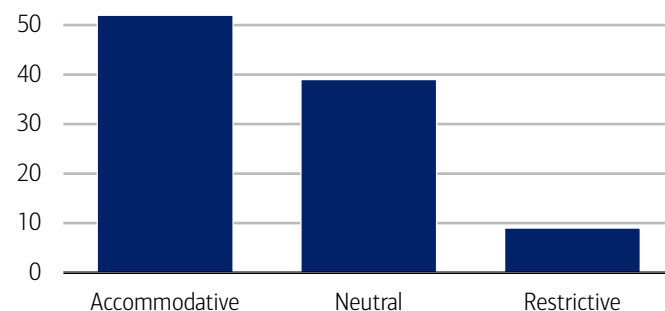


Source: Bloomberg; note: lower value = easier financial conditions

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Exhibit 3: Clients see US monetary policy as accommodative

% of responses to Q: “My view on the current stance of US monetary policy”



Source: BofA Global Research; note: responses sum views on “very” or “modestly” accommodative
See report: [FX and Rates Sentiment Survey: Buyers’ regret 11 September 2026](#)

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Commodity risks: we remain concerned about upside commodity risks, especially as crack spreads widened (Exhibit 5) & expectations for Hormuz normalization have dwindled (Exhibit 6). Prolonged refined product disruption risk seems high to us.

Technical support: Paul Ciana sees upside risk to real & nominal rates (see report: [A real-ly risky time? Hut hut, hike!](#)): “uptrends in US real yields are currently stretched, we show they could still rise more”. He also suggests owning downside risk protection.

Trades: (1) short 2Y UST: entry = 4.73%, current = 4.83%, target = 5.25%, stop 4.45%, risks: econ slowdown / jobs slow while inflation drops. (2) 2s30s flattener: entry = 62bp, current = 79bp, target 40bp, stop = 100bp, risk: dovish Fed.

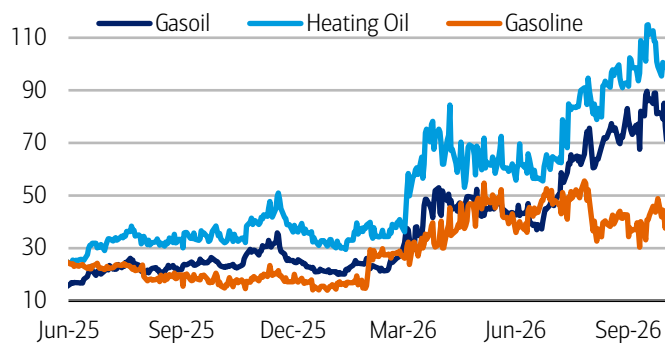


Insight | 05 October 2026

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Exhibit 4: Crack spreads, front month contract (\$)

Crack spreads have widened amidst global refinery disruptions

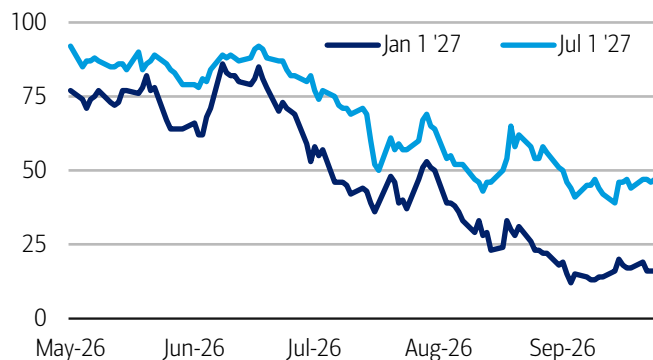


Source: Bloomberg

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Exhibit 5: Kalshi odds for when “traffic at Hormuz return to normal?”

Market is increasingly pessimistic for when Hormuz traffic will normalize



Source: Bloomberg citing Kalshi

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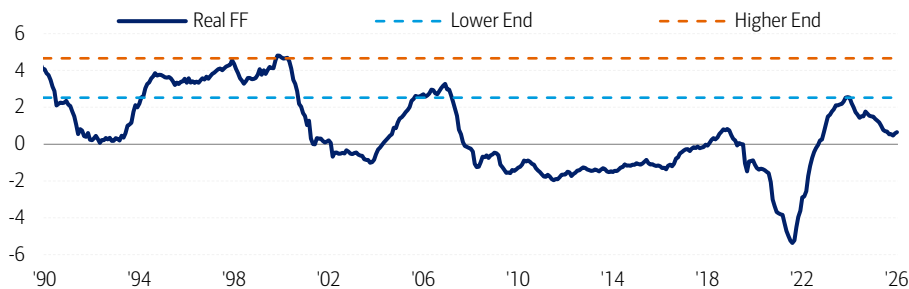
Conviction lower: pricing, Fed push back, some rate bite

Our pay 2Y & curve flattening view conviction has been reduced due to:

Market pricing: market gap to one of our preferred rate frameworks has been reduced. Taylor rule = 1Y forward Fed pricing has closed to recommended Taylor rate of 4.8% (Taylor rate also dropped with core PCE data & U3 uptick; Exhibit 2). There is still large gap vs our other preferred framework. Real FF history = still implies 80bps of upside vs mkt to reach typical real FF hiking cycle lower bound (assuming 3% core PCE; Exhibit 7).

Exhibit 6: Real fed funds rate (%)

In a typical tightening cycle, the real FF rate peaks at 2.5-4.5%



Source: Bloomberg; Note: real funds rate = nominal FF less core PCE

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Fed push back: Warsh deputies provided clear (& ironic) forward guidance last week: Williams = “no need for urgency”, Jefferson = “more time”. Warsh & company clearly want to tap brake on market pricing. We got the signal but also recall Fed being very offside in last cycle (Dec '21 SEP = 150bp hikes by end '23, Fed delivery = 525bps). Dynamics are different today, but Fed may underappreciate extent of AI boom impact.

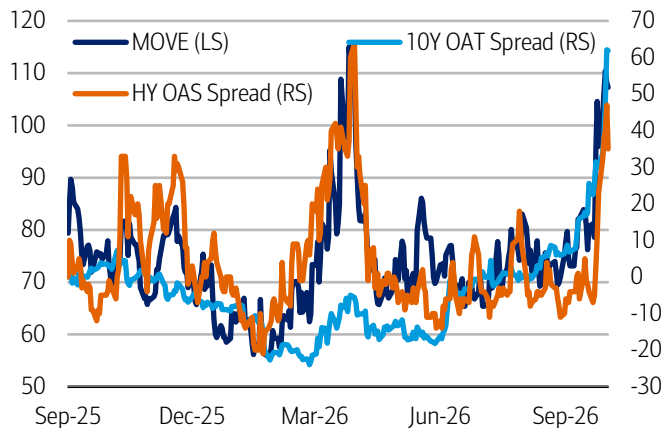
Rate bite: fin conditions are easy amidst some signs of higher rate bite. Rate vol, French bonds, & HY spreads all seem linked (Exhibit 8). Broader rate impact is limited but higher yields likely to bite more (Exhibit 9). Downside risk asset hedges seem sensible.

De-risking: asset managers agree with higher rate bite risk. Our metrics say they have reduced UST underweight, pared MBS long, and are now slightly underweight IG (Exhibit 11, Exhibit 12, Exhibit 13). Reduced risk appetite = increased demand for USTs.

Overall, we continue to believe that US rates will remain elevated or rise further until macro data softens or financial conditions tighten. We do not believe either condition has yet been sufficiently met, which should support ongoing sticky inflation concern. It should also support upside rate & Fed hike risks. We see risks higher rates shift from front-end to belly / back end if Fed keeps guiding dovish, challenging flattener view.

Exhibit 7: US rate vol, French bond spread, & HY OAS

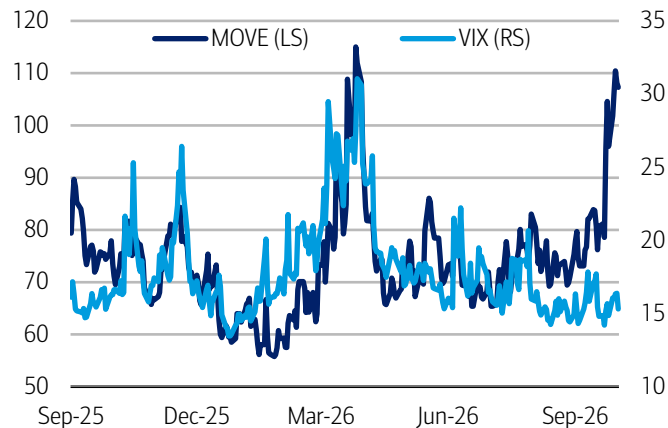
US rate vol jump has supported widening in France & US HY OAS



Source: Bloomberg; note: RS = change in 10Y OAT & HY OAS spread since Sep 1 '25 in bps
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Exhibit 8: MOVE & VIX indices (pts)

MOVE spiked, VIX flat

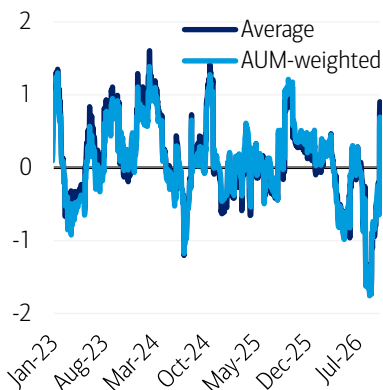


Source: Bloomberg

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Exhibit 9: UST beta from PCA regression (z-score)

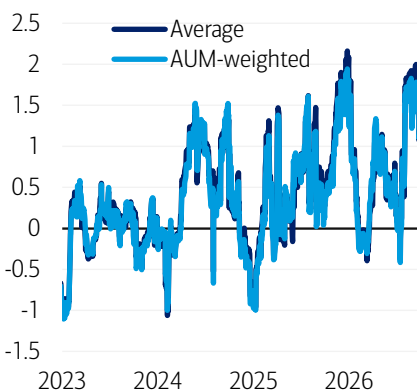
Betas suggest funds are overweight benchmark duration; higher beta = funds' overweight duration versus benchmark



Source: BofA Global Research, Bloomberg, Z-score calculated over fund beta differences vs Agg back to May 2015
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Exhibit 10: MBS beta from PCA regression (z-score)

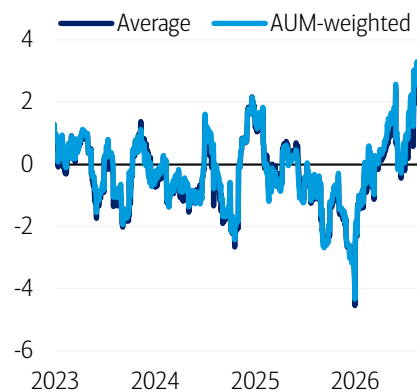
Betas suggest funds are overweight MBS; higher beta = funds overweight MBS versus benchmark



Source: BofA Global Research, Bloomberg, Z-score calculated over fund beta differences vs Agg back to May 2015
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Exhibit 11: IG beta from PCA regression (z-score)

Betas suggest funds are underweight IG risk; higher beta = funds overweight IG versus benchmark



Source: BofA Global Research, Bloomberg, Z-score calculated over fund beta differences vs Agg
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Bottom line: stay paid 2Y UST & in flatteners. Higher front-end rates should be supported by strong US economy, easy fin conditions, commodity risks, & technicals. Our conviction has been reduced to market pricing, Fed guidance, small rate bite, and de-risking. US data softening or larger FCI tightening needed to shift views. Higher rates may shift from front-end to belly / back end if Fed stays dovish, challenging flatteners.



Notable Rates and FX Research

- **Global Macro Year Ahead 2026** – [Attitude determines altitude](#), 23 November 2025
- **Global Rates Year Ahead 2026** – [When carry met rally](#), 25 November 2025
- **G10 FX Year Ahead 2026** – [the \(USD\) long and short of it](#), 25 November 2025
- [2025 reflections](#) **Liquid Cross Border Flows**, 8 December 2025

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[Global FX weekly: Déjà EUR 02 October 2026](#)

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